

“Women are **not like men** in sensual matters. They ... do **not love lust for lust's sake**. **Passion must come** to them **accompanied** not only **with love**, but with ... **kindness** ...”

ELIZA BISBEE DUFFEY, *THE RELATIONS OF THE SEXES*, 1889

that sex advice was privately passed on among women long before modern women's magazines such as *Cosmopolitan* began to publish tips for the average reader. Some women went against social taboos to write treatises and pamphlets to teach their peers about sex. One such writer was Ida Craddock of Philadelphia, who distributed a pamphlet called “The Wedding Night” in 1902, and took her own life to avoid the jail sentence that would have followed.

Erotic art and poetry have also always existed, created by women as well as men. In ancient China, erotic poems were written by both sexes, and female bhakti poets (see pp. 74–75) in India wrote sexual odes to their gods. In the 20th century, female writers pushed boundaries to write about female desires and experiences. Anaïs Nin's 1940s collection of erotic short stories *Delta of Venus*, published posthumously in 1977, were unflinchingly explicit.

### Sexual revolution

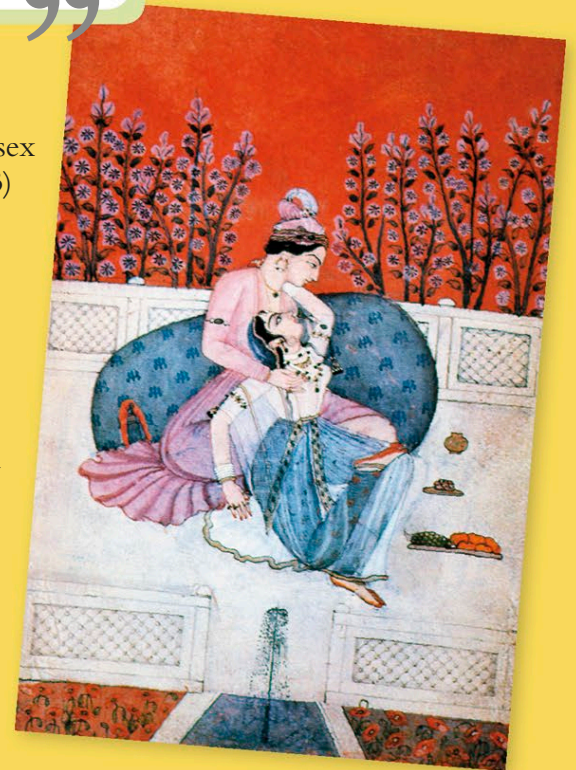
The more liberal climate of the postwar years encouraged scientific studies of sexuality that attempted to pinpoint the source of the female orgasm, opening up the topic for debate. In 1948 and 1953, American sociologist Alfred Kinsey shocked readers with his studies, known as the Kinsey Reports, about both male and female sexuality; this contributed to a change in public opinion about sexuality, and helped to lay the groundwork for the “Sexual Revolution” of the 1960s. The Hite Report (1976), a collection of first-hand accounts from women, also drew attention to the subject.

Changing attitudes, plus the availability of birth control (see pp. 278–279) from the '60s onward, have given women in the West

increased freedom to explore both sex and sexual identity (see pp. 302–303) outside the confines of marriage and heterosexuality. In the 1980s, a “sex positive” movement sprang up among some feminists, who embraced all forms of consensual sexual activity, including pornography. This alienated other feminists who viewed pornography as a form of male oppression.

### ► Guided pleasures

A 19th-century illumination from the *Kama Sutra* depicts lovers in an embrace. Written in the 3rd century CE, this manual of sexual pleasure was intended to be read by both men and women alike.



“I am a **winged creature** who is **too rarely allowed** to use its **wings**. **Ecstasies** do not occur **often enough**.”

ANAÏS NIN, *DELTA OF VENUS*, 1977